

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MALI

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the rivers, wetlands, and land of Mali. Community action genuinely shapes what happens to the rivers, the wetlands, and the land of Mali — and here the stakes are the water and food of millions, in a nation where a gold boom poisons the water even as a great inland delta that feeds the country is squeezed dry, and where the work must be done carefully, in a land under military rule and gripped by conflict. Mali's life flows from the Niger River and, above all, from the Inner Niger Delta at its heart — one of the world's great inland wetlands, which sustains some one and a half million people, yields most of the nation's fish and half its dry-season livestock, and grows its floating rice. It yields the great majority of the nation's fish and sustains half of its dry-season livestock, and grows its distinctive floating rice — a lifeline now threatened by dams proposed upstream, by the diversion of its water for irrigation, and by a deepening drought. At the same time, Mali is one of Africa's great gold producers, and its gold, dug both in industrial mines and by countless small-scale miners, is won with mercury and cyanide that poison the rivers and soil and the health of those who live by them. Its gold, dug both in large industrial mines and by countless small-scale miners across the land, is won with mercury and cyanide that poison the rivers and the soil and the health of those who live by them. This guide will be honest that gold is a mainstay of the nation and the livelihood of millions, so the aim is to clean it up, not to end it; This guide will be honest throughout that gold is a genuine mainstay of the nation and the livelihood of many millions, so the realistic aim is to clean it up, not to end it; that the delta's threats come partly from upstream in another country and from Mali's own need for food and power; that the nation is poor, under military rule, and beset by insecurity and conflict across much of its territory, so the work must be careful and the vulnerable protected; and that no single victory is to be won. But it will show that the levers here — the case against the poison of the gold, the defence of the delta that feeds millions, the livelihoods at stake, the international frameworks, and the channels of community and expertise — are real, and can be used, with care.

The Malian story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Malian, and it is what gives this guide its particular force. **Because the poison of the gold can be reduced through global frameworks and safer ways, because the delta that feeds millions can be defended through the river's shared governance, because the livelihoods of fishers, farmers, and herders are a powerful and unifying stake, because international frameworks and partners reach a poor and aid-dependent state, and because community and expertise are channels even a troubled nation permits, the levers run through health, the lifeline, and livelihoods: the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels.** That combination — the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a poor, conflict-affected nation whose water and food are at stake, the strongest ground is the health and livelihood of the people and the frameworks the world provides.

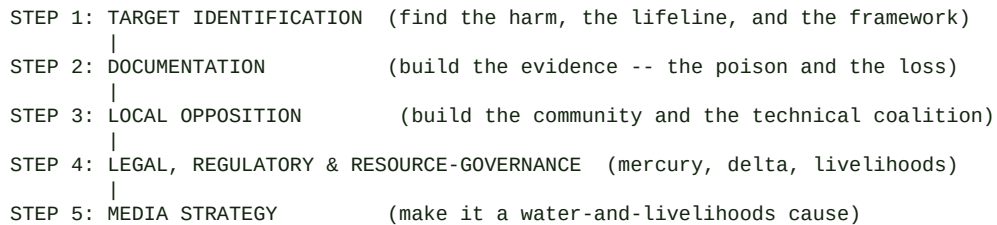
But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **Gold is a mainstay, the delta's threats are complex, the nation is troubled and insecure, and no victory is final.** Gold is a pillar of the economy and the livelihood of millions of small-scale miners, so ending it is neither possible nor just, and the aim must be to reduce its poison and share its benefit; the delta's threats arise partly from a dam proposed upstream in Guinea and from Mali's own need for food and electricity, so the question is careful management, not simple refusal; the nation is poor, under military rule, and gripped by insecurity and conflict across much of its land, so open opposition is constrained and dangerous, and the work must run carefully through community, technical, and international channels, protecting the vulnerable; and there is no landmark victory to point to. This guide does not pretend gold can be wished away, or that the delta's fate is simple, or that the conditions are safe. What it shows is how, through the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels, Malians and their allies can reduce the poison, defend the lifeline, and protect the water and food of millions — carefully, within the troubled conditions that exist.

Most people who care about Mali's environment do not know HOW to use the levers a poor, resource-rich, troubled nation offers. They see the rivers poisoned by mining, the delta drying, the water and fish threatened — and either accept it as the price of gold and the burden of a hard land, or despair amid the insecurity, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the global mercury frameworks, the river's shared governance, the livelihoods at stake, the international partners, the channels of community and expertise. The gap between the water and food defended and the water and food lost is here often a gap of method — the method of using the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Malian reality as it is, which is a poor, gold-rich, water-dependent nation under military rule and gripped by conflict. It is written for the person — in a fishing, farming, herding, or mining community, in Mali's technical world, or among its international partners — who sees the water poisoned and the delta drying and wants to know what can be done in a troubled nation where the water and food of millions are at stake. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels — with the honest qualifiers that gold is a mainstay, the delta's threats complex, the nation troubled and insecure, and no victory final, so the work is careful, community-and-international, protecting the vulnerable, not open confrontation. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Malian case is particular and demands the greatest care. It is for the person — a member of a fishing, farming, herding, or mining community, someone in Mali's technical or scientific world, or an international partner — willing to do the patient, careful, and safe work of reducing the poison of the gold and defending the lifeline of the delta through health, livelihoods, and the world's frameworks, rather than either accepting the poisoning of the water as the unchangeable price of gold or attempting the open confrontation that a military-ruled, conflict-torn land makes both ineffective and dangerous. That is not a lesser ambition but, in Mali's conditions, the effective and responsible one, because here the levers that genuinely deliver are the health of the people, the defence of the delta, the livelihoods, and the international frameworks, all of which are reached through the community and the partners rather than through confrontation. Anyone who approaches Mali recklessly may endanger the very communities they mean to help; anyone who approaches it carefully, through the frameworks and the community and with the safety of the vulnerable always first, can genuinely help defend the water and food of millions. This guide is an honest map of that careful path.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to a poor, troubled, resource-dependent nation:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of the poison and the loss feeds the mercury case, the delta's defence, and the livelihoods argument at once; the community and the technical experts organise carefully together; a health argument, a river-governance claim, or an international framework is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still constrained — chance of defending the water, the delta, and the food of millions.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Mali's — a poor, gold-rich, delta-fed, troubled nation — give a distinctive set:

- **The mercury case.** The **poison of the gold** — the mercury and cyanide in the water and soil — can be reduced through global frameworks and safer ways, the distinctive lever.
- **The delta's defence.** The **Inner Niger Delta that feeds millions** can be defended through the river's shared, transboundary governance.
- **The livelihoods.** The **fishing, farming, and herding** the water sustains are a powerful, unifying, non-ideological stake.
- **The frameworks.** The **global mercury, river-basin, and wetland frameworks** reach a poor, aid-dependent state and its miners and companies.
- **The community channels.** The **affected communities, the technical experts, and the international partners** are channels even a troubled nation permits.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that gold can be ended, or that the conditions are safe. Gold is a **mainstay**; the delta's threats are **complex**; the nation is **troubled and insecure**; and no victory is **final**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it seeks to clean up and defend, not to refuse or endanger — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels — to reduce the poison and defend the water and food of millions, honestly acknowledging the gold-dependence, the complex threats, the troubled conditions, and the unfinished work.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run through the health and livelihood of the people, the river's shared governance, and the world's frameworks, because in a poor, troubled, military-ruled nation open opposition is constrained but the water and food of millions are a stake no one can dismiss. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods,

the frameworks, and the community channels apply, because in Mali a destructive harm is met not by open confrontation, which is dangerous, nor by ending the gold that feeds millions, but by reducing the poison, defending the lifeline, and protecting the livelihoods, through the frameworks and the community.

The Levels of Decision

A Malian environmental harm runs through a poor, centralised, troubled system.

The state and its agencies. The **transitional government, the mines and environment ministries, and the water agencies** decide and permit, and are the authority to be engaged — carefully — on the health, the lifeline, and the frameworks.

The mining sector. The **industrial mining companies and the vast artisanal sector** drive the gold and its poison, and are where cleaner practice and benefit must be pressed.

The river's shared governance. The **Niger Basin Authority and the transboundary river framework** govern the shared river and the delta, and give standing over upstream dams and diversions.

The international frameworks and partners. The **global mercury and wetland frameworks, the donors, and the NGOs** carry the standards and the support that reach a poor state.

The affected communities. The **fishers, farmers, herders, and miners** who bear the harm and the poison can act, carefully, on their health and livelihoods.

The Journey of a Harm

A Malian harm — mining poisoning a river, a dam or diversion drying the delta, a mine degrading the land — meets the **mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels**. The **mercury case and the delta's defence are where the harm is best met, and the livelihoods and the frameworks are what carry them** — and using them together, carefully, is the distinctive Malian approach. The distinctive levers are the **mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels**. Find out exactly where the harm stands, and, crucially, **what water, delta, or land it poisons or dries, whose livelihood and health it threatens, and how the frameworks and the community can be brought to bear**, because those are where a harm can genuinely be met.

Follow the Harm, the Water, and the Livelihood

Behind a harm stand the miners or the planners, the gold or the water, and the livelihoods at stake. Trace who decides, who benefits, what is harmed, and — importantly here — **what water or delta it poisons or dries, whose health and livelihood it threatens, what framework applies, and how the community and the partners can act**. Two questions unlock most Malian efforts: **What is harmed, and whose water, food, and health does it threaten?** and **Which lever — the mercury case, the delta, the livelihoods, the frameworks, the community — can meet it, carefully?** The mercury case, the delta's defence, and the livelihoods are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Malian effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the poison and the loss and their harm to the water and food of millions; the community-and-framework coalition exists to press that case through the affected people, the experts, and the partners; and the careful, international media exists to reach a poor, aid-dependent state and the world's frameworks. Keep the mercury case, the delta's defence, and the livelihoods at the centre of every submission, claim, and appeal, and the effort retains a clear spine that runs from a single poisoned river or drying reach of the delta to the water, food, and health of millions, grounding the whole effort in the health, the lifeline, and the livelihoods that a poor, troubled, gold-dependent nation

cannot finally ignore.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a harm, because they are the levers. The **transitional government, the mines, environment, and water ministries**; the **mining sector**; the **Niger Basin Authority and the river framework**; the **global frameworks and partners**; and the **affected communities**. In Mali, the **mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a harm shown to poison the water, dry the delta that feeds millions, or threaten the livelihoods of the vulnerable can genuinely be pressed — through the mercury case, the delta's defence, and the frameworks — though, honestly, gold is a mainstay, the delta's threats complex, the nation troubled and insecure, and no victory final, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working carefully through health, the lifeline, and livelihoods.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that gold is a mainstay, the delta's threats are complex, and the nation is troubled and insecure, even as the mercury case, the delta's defence, and the livelihoods give real leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how environmental efforts tend to go in Mali and comparable poor, resource-dependent, troubled states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the harm can be **documented and tied to health, the lifeline, or a framework**, whether the **livelihoods** can be shown, and whether the **international frameworks and partners** can be brought to bear. Where the harm to water and food is clear and the frameworks engaged, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that gold is a mainstay, the conditions insecure, and open confrontation dangerous.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Mercury / health case	35–55%	months–years	low	The poison reduced, safer ways advanced
Delta-defence / river framework	35–55%	years	low	The delta's flood and flow defended
Livelihoods argument	40–60%	months–years	low	The fishing, farming, herding protected
International-frameworks route	40–60%	months–years	low	The mercury, wetland, basin frameworks used
Community / technical	35–55%	months–years	low	The affected mobilised, the science marshalled
Mining-sector / benefit	30–50%	years	low	Cleaner practice, benefit-sharing pressed
All levers together	35–55%	months–years	moderate	Poison reduced; water and food defended

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Mali's real strengths are the health and livelihood of its people and the world's frameworks: the **mercury case**, the **delta's defence**, the

A note on cost and risk: most levers here — a health case, a livelihoods argument, an international framework, a community effort — cost mainly organisation, knowledge, and care. But the risk is real: the nation is insecure and conflict-affected, so the safety of those involved, especially vulnerable communities, must come first. The scarce resources are **the technical and scientific capacity, the international connections, and the careful navigation of a troubled land** — much of it reachable through the frameworks, the donors, and the NGOs. This shapes where a Malian effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are technical and scientific credibility, connection to the international frameworks and partners, and above all the judgement to navigate a troubled, insecure land safely — rather than the mass mobilisation that other struggles rely on and that here is dangerous — an effort's most valuable investments are in building technical credibility, cultivating the international framework and partner relationships, and documenting the poison and the loss rigorously while keeping the vulnerable safe. A small, credible, well-connected effort that can marshal the scientific record, make the health and livelihoods case, engage the mercury and river frameworks, and enlist the international partners can accomplish a great deal in a poor, aid-dependent state, and can do so without exposing communities to danger. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of credibility, connection, and careful judgement — much of it reachable through the international mercury, wetland, and river frameworks, the donors, and the NGOs that share a concern for Mali's water, delta, and health. And because the state is poor and aid-dependent, the arguments grounded in health, livelihoods, and the international frameworks it has joined are the most persuasive.

```

MERCURY + DELTA + LIVELIHOODS + FRAMEWORKS + COMMUNITY:
Livelihoods argument:      ██████████ 40-60%
International-frameworks route: ██████████ 40-60%
Mercury / health case:     ██████████ 35-55%
Delta-defence / river:     ██████████ 35-55%
Community / technical:     ██████████ 35-55%

GOLD A MAINSTAY / COMPLEX THREATS / INSECURE -- harder ground:
Ending the gold:           ██ impossible, unjust
Cleaning up and defending:   ██████████ the real path
Water and food defended:   ██████████ achievable in part
The harm documented:       ██████████ the reliable foundation

```

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The livelihoods and the international frameworks** — Mali's distinctive strengths; the unifying stake and the world's standards.
2. **The mercury case and the delta's defence** — the poison reduced and the lifeline defended.
3. **The community channels** — the affected and the experts, carefully mobilised.
4. **The mining sector and benefit-sharing** — cleaner practice and shared benefit pressed.
5. **The documented harm** — the evidence of the poison and the loss that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The poison is real and reducible** — mercury and cyanide harm health and can be curbed through safer ways and global frameworks. **The delta feeds millions** — its defence is a stake no one can dismiss. **Livelihoods unify** — the fishing, farming, and herding cross every divide. **The frameworks reach a poor state** — the mercury, wetland, and basin frameworks carry weight. **But gold is a mainstay and the land is troubled** — so the work is careful, cleaning-up-and-defending, not ending or confronting. The through-line: **document the poison and the loss; make the health and livelihoods case; defend the delta through the river framework; use the global frameworks; work carefully through the community; and protect the vulnerable** — because an effort that does can genuinely reduce the poison and defend the water and food of millions, while being honest that gold is a mainstay, the conditions insecure, and no victory final.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact harm — and the leverage, which here runs through health, the lifeline, and the frameworks. Vague concern goes nowhere, and ending gold is impossible; an effort aimed at "this harm — this mining poison, this drying of the delta — threatening this water, food, and health, which the mercury frameworks, the river's governance, and the community can address" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What is harmed?** This is the first question here. What **water, delta, or land** is harmed — the poisoned river, the drying delta, the contaminated soil, the degraded land.
2. **Whose water, food, and health does it threaten?** Whose **livelihood and health** the harm threatens — the fishers, farmers, herders, miners, and communities who depend on the water and land.
3. **What poison or loss, and what framework?** What **poison** (the mercury and cyanide) or **loss** (the delta's flood and flow) is at stake, and what **framework** — mercury, wetland, or river-basin — applies.
4. **What livelihoods are at stake?** How the harm threatens the **fishing, farming, and herding** of millions, the unifying stake.
5. **How can the community and frameworks act, safely?** How the **affected communities, the technical experts, and the international partners** can act, carefully, protecting the vulnerable in a troubled land.

A Worked Example

Suppose gold mining poisons a river with mercury, harming the health and the fishing of the communities who depend on it, in a region where safer practices and the global mercury framework could reduce the

harm.

Working the five questions: **what is harmed? Whose water, food, and health? What poison, and what framework? What livelihoods?** And how can the community and frameworks act, safely? The driver is the gold and its poison, with the mercury case, the health, the livelihoods, and the frameworks as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "gold is king and the poison cannot be stopped" to a real, careful effort: document the poison and its harm to health and fishing; make the health and livelihoods case; press safer practices and the global mercury framework; and work carefully through the community and the partners — all protecting the vulnerable. That is a workable effort suited to Mali — one that reduces the poison without ending the gold that feeds millions. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight in a poor, gold-dependent, troubled land: they turn what might seem an impossible situation — a nation dependent on the very gold that poisons its water, its lifeline threatened from upstream and by drought, its land insecure — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that works through the health and livelihood of the people and the world's frameworks rather than through a confrontation the conditions forbid. The harm becomes a documentable poison or loss. The stake becomes the water, food, and health of millions. The framework becomes the global standard Mali has joined. The livelihoods become the unifying cause. And the community and partners become the safe, effective channels. That translation — from a seemingly hopeless situation into a set of specific actions that reduce the poison and defend the lifeline through health, livelihoods, and the frameworks — is the first and most important thing a Malian effort does, because it moves the fight from the despair of a poor nation trapped by its gold onto the ground of the people's basic needs and the world's standards, where careful, effective work is genuinely possible.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, the decisive evidence is the poison in the water and the loss of the delta, and their harm to health and livelihoods. A ministry, a mining company, the river authority, an international partner, and the community all move on evidence — and in Mali, a clear record of the poison, the loss, and their harm to the water and food of millions is precisely what a careful effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Harm, the Water, and the Livelihood

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **harm and its source** — the mine and the mercury it releases, the dam and the delta it dries, the diversion and the flood it steals — and, decisively here, **the water, food, and health it threatens**: the poisoned river, the drying delta, the fishing and farming and herding at stake. Establish exactly **what the harm is and whose water, food, and health it threatens**, because the harm-to-the-lifeline is the case's foundation.

Layer 2: The Poison, the Loss, and the Science

Document the harm with the science. Establish the **poison** — the mercury and cyanide in the water and soil, their levels and their spread — and the **loss** — the delta's reduced flood, the diverted flow, the degraded land — and their **harm to health and livelihoods** — drawing on **the scientific studies, the health data, the river-basin assessments, and the community's knowledge**. This poison-and-loss evidence turns the harm into a documented threat to the health and the food of millions.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Framework, the Community, and the Care

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **harm** poison the water, dry the delta, or threaten health and livelihoods? What **framework** — mercury, wetland, river-basin — applies? How will the **community and partners** act? And how will the **vulnerable be protected** in a troubled land? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case grounded in health, livelihoods, and the frameworks. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented poison, a threatened lifeline, an applicable framework, and a careful, protected path are exactly what let a Malian effort defend the water and food of millions. Build it well, and the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels become the effort's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: because Mali's water, delta, and mercury are subjects of genuine international scientific and institutional attention, a great deal of the necessary evidence already exists in studies, assessments, and monitoring conducted by researchers, river-basin bodies, wetland organisations, and the mercury framework's own processes, which spares an effort much of the burden of generating it from scratch in dangerous conditions. The mercury and cyanide pollution of West African gold mining has been studied and measured; the Inner Niger Delta's vital role and the threats to it from upstream dams, irrigation diversion, and drought have been assessed by Malian and international partnerships; the river basin's flows and the delta's flood are monitored. This means an effort can often build its file substantially from that existing scientific and institutional record, drawing on the studies, the assessments, and the frameworks' own data, rather than exposing communities to danger to gather it anew. Building this layer well therefore means seeking out and marshalling that existing record — the pollution studies, the delta assessments, the basin monitoring, the framework reports — and joining it to the community's own knowledge, so that the case rests on a solid, largely-available evidentiary foundation while keeping the vulnerable safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here much of it lives in the scientific studies, the river-basin assessments, and the community's own knowledge. Here is where the material tends to live in a Malian effort, and how to get it — with the **poison**, the **loss**, the **livelihood**, and the **framework** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Harm, Water, and Livelihood Record

Start with the harm and whose lifeline it threatens. **The mining and water records, the environmental data, and the livelihood picture** establish the harm and the stake; the distinctive strengths here are the **documented poison** and the **delta's vital role**, both well studied. Establish the **harm and the water, food, and health it threatens**, drawing on the studies and the community. Establish exactly **what is harmed and whose lifeline it threatens**, because a harm to the water and food of millions is a stake no one can dismiss.

The Poison, Loss, and Science Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **poison evidence** — the mercury and cyanide levels in the water, soil, and fish, their spread and their sources — and the **loss evidence** — the delta's reduced flood, the diverted flow, the drought's toll — and their **harm to health and livelihoods** — drawing on **the scientific studies, the health and water data, the river-basin assessments, and the community's knowledge**. This poison-and-loss evidence is what turns the harm into a documented threat to the health and food of millions.

The Framework and Governance Record

Document the levers of the frameworks. Gather the record of **the global mercury framework** and safer mining practices; **the transboundary river-basin governance** and its assessments of upstream dams and diversions; and **the wetland's international status**. A community that understands the mercury, river-basin, and wetland frameworks holds the levers that reach a poor state, its miners, and the upstream actors through the world's standards.

The International, Partner, and Sector Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **international partners** — the donors, the NGOs, the wetland and river organisations — who support the delta and the water; and the **mining sector** — the companies, the artisanal reality, the benefit and the practices. A community joined to the international partners and mindful of the mining sector holds levers that reach a poor, aid-dependent state and its gold economy.

The People, the Care, and the Protection

Finally, map the human terrain and the careful path, which here is a matter of safety. Who is affected — the **fishers, farmers, herders, miners, and communities** who bear the poison and the loss — and who can act: the **technical experts, the international partners, and the community**, carefully. And how does the effort **protect the vulnerable and navigate a troubled, insecure land**? A Malian effort is advanced through the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community, with the greatest care for safety — so map that coalition deliberately, and let the protection of the vulnerable and a realistic sense of the insecurity govern every step.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood carefully, because Mali is under military rule and gripped by conflict, so open, adversarial organising is constrained and, in many areas, dangerous, and the "opposition" that works joins the affected communities to the technical experts and the international partners, pressing through health, livelihoods, and the frameworks, with the safety of the vulnerable first. The task is to build a community — of fishers, farmers, herders, miners, and experts — that presses for reduced poison and a defended lifeline, carefully, protecting all involved.

Why the Community-and-Framework Coalition Is Decisive

In Mali, the community that can act joins the affected people to the technical experts and the international frameworks, because a poor, troubled, aid-dependent state responds to health, livelihoods, and the world's standards more than to open dissent, which the conditions make dangerous. That coalition supplies what a careful effort runs on: the affected communities who bear the poison and the loss, the technical experts whose evidence carries weight, and — distinctively — the international frameworks and partners for whom Mali's water and delta are a shared concern. When affected communities, experts, and partners press for reduced poison and a defended lifeline, they become a genuine force. **A coalition that joins the affected communities to the experts and the international partners here is not a weaker substitute for open protest; it is the safer and more effective form advocacy can take in a troubled, insecure Mali — the real foundation of an effort, defending the water and food of millions through health, the frameworks, and care.** This is worth dwelling on, because the particular conditions of Mali make this careful, coalition-based approach not a fallback but the genuinely effective and responsible one. In a stable, open society, the strength of an environmental effort might lie in mass public mobilisation; in a nation under military rule and gripped by conflict, where much of the land is insecure and speaking out can be dangerous,

that avenue is both constrained and perilous, and its reckless pursuit could endanger the very communities it means to help. But Mali's situation offers a different strength: a harm to the water and food of millions is a stake so basic, so human, and so unifying that it draws support across every divide and reaches the international frameworks and partners for whom the delta, the river, and the mercury are shared global concerns. The task, therefore, is to build the coalition that joins the local and the global: the affected communities' testimony and knowledge on the ground, the technical experts' evidence, and the international frameworks' standards and support from beyond. This is not a weaker path but, in Mali's conditions, the wiser and safer one, for it advances the defence of the water and food of millions through channels that carry weight without exposing the vulnerable to the dangers that open confrontation would bring.

Finding the Community

Begin with those the harm touches and those who can act — the **fishing, farming, herding, and mining communities, the technical experts, and the international partners** — and treat the insecurity with the utmost seriousness, protecting everyone involved. Widen with care to all who share the water and the delta. Name the shared stake — **our water, our fish, our herds, our land, and our children's health** — because the water and the delta are the life and food of the nation. Frame the effort around health, livelihoods, and the defence of the lifeline, not around confrontation. There is real power, and real safety, in framing the cause this way, because it grounds the effort in stakes that unite rather than divide and that no one can easily oppose. A campaign framed as confrontation with the authorities or the mining interests would be dangerous in a military-ruled, insecure land, and would invite repression. A campaign framed around the water people drink, the fish and herds they live on, and the health of their children casts the effort not as opposition but as the defence of the most basic needs of the people, a cause that fishers, farmers, herders, and miners alike can embrace, and that the state, the companies, and the international partners find hard to reject. This framing is not only safer; it is also truer, because the real stake genuinely is the water, food, and health of millions, and the aim genuinely is to reduce the poison and defend the lifeline, not to end the gold or challenge the order. An effort that names this stake precisely — health, livelihoods, and the defence of the lifeline — stands on the broadest, safest, and most unifying ground the Malian situation affords.

Coalition-Building, Through Community and Frameworks

A coalition allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Mali it runs through the community, the experts, and the frameworks. Reach, with care, to the **affected communities; the technical and scientific experts; the international partners, NGOs, and river and wetland bodies; and the mining-sector and benefit channels**. Frame the coalition around the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, and the frameworks. Build breadth carefully, favouring the community and international routes over confrontation, and protecting the vulnerable in a troubled land.

Sustaining the Effort

Malian efforts are sustained through health, livelihoods, the frameworks, and care. Keep the community **informed, connected, and safe**; mark real steps — a poison reduced, a delta flow defended, a livelihood protected, a framework advanced. And keep the effort grounded in health, the lifeline, and the livelihoods, which unite and endure. The effort that lasts is the one that joins the affected communities to the experts and the partners, presses health and the lifeline, and works carefully through the channels that are safe.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & RESOURCE-GOVERNANCE CHALLENGES — THE MERCURY FRAMEWORK, THE DELTA'S DEFENCE, AND THE LIVELIHOODS

This is where a Malian effort is realistically advanced — not through open confrontation, which is dangerous, nor through ending the gold that feeds millions, but through the **global mercury framework, the defence of the delta, and the livelihoods**, grounded in health, the lifeline, and the world's standards. Here the mercury, delta, and livelihoods levers come together, because in Mali a harm that poisons the water or dries the delta, threatening the health and food of millions, can be pressed through those levers, carefully.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but work within a poor, troubled, gold-dependent state**. The mercury framework is **real but the artisanal reality is vast and hard to change quickly**; the delta's defence is **vital but its threats are partly upstream and partly Mali's own need**; the livelihoods are **a powerful stake but the conditions insecure**; and gold is **a mainstay**. What these levers realistically achieve is **the poison reduced, safer practices advanced, the delta's flow defended, the livelihoods protected, and the frameworks applied** — real outcomes, if not the end of the gold economy or the full command of the river. Enter this front clear-eyed: the mercury framework, the delta's defence, and the livelihoods are Mali's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm to health and the lifeline is clearly documented** — but gold is a mainstay, the threats complex, and the conditions insecure.

The Mercury Framework and the Health Case

The first front is the poison and health. The gold won with **mercury and cyanide** poisons the water, soil, and fish and harms the health of miners and communities, so pressing the **global mercury framework** Mali has joined — and with it safer, mercury-free practices, the formalisation and support of artisanal miners, and the cleaner practice of industrial mines — is a genuine lever, because it reduces the poison without ending the gold millions depend on. And the **public-health case** — the poisoned water and fish, the harm to health — is a powerful, unifying argument. Use the mercury framework and the health case together, because the global standard and the concrete harm are the case's core, and reducing the poison, not ending the gold, is the realistic and just aim. Note, too, that heavy-handed crackdowns on artisanal mining tend to scatter miners and worsen the harm, so support and safer ways, not force, are the path. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this mercury-and-health front, honestly, for it is one of the most distinctive a Malian effort holds. Its power is real: the harm is concrete and measurable, the poison reaches the water and food and health of everyone downstream, and the global mercury framework gives a recognised standard and a body of support for reducing it, so the argument is both locally compelling and globally backed. Its limits are equally real: artisanal gold mining is the livelihood of a great many people, it is dispersed across vast and often insecure areas, and the mercury is cheap and effective, so change comes not by prohibition but by the slow, supported spread of safer, mercury-free methods and by the formalisation and support of miners rather than their persecution. Understanding both means using the mercury-and-health front for what it does best — documenting the poison, making the health case, and advancing the global framework and safer practices — while recognising that the aim is the gradual reduction of the poison through support and better ways, not a sudden end that would only scatter the miners, deepen their poverty, and, as experience shows, spread the harm to new and untouched places.

The Delta's Defence and the River Framework

The second front is the delta and the river. The **Inner Niger Delta** that feeds millions is threatened by upstream dams like the one proposed in Guinea, by the diversion of water for irrigation, and by drought, so defending the delta's flood and flow through the **transboundary river-basin framework** — the shared governance of the Niger, the requirement for proper assessment of upstream dams and diversions, and sustainable water management — is a genuine lever, because it gives Mali and its people standing over the river that sustains them. Press the delta's defence and the river framework, because the flood that feeds millions is a stake the shared governance is meant to protect, exercised through the basin authority and careful diplomacy, mindful that the threats are partly upstream and partly Mali's own need for food and power.

The Livelihoods and the International Frameworks

The third front is the livelihoods and the frameworks. The **fishing, farming, and herding** the water and delta sustain are the food and living of millions, and framing the whole effort around them is powerful and unifying, because they cross every divide and are a stake no one can dismiss. And the **international frameworks and partners** — the mercury and wetland conventions, the river basin authority, the donors and NGOs — reach a poor, aid-dependent state and carry the standards and the support. Pursued together — the mercury framework, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, and the international frameworks — these fronts are how a Malian effort reduces the poison and defends the water and food of millions, through health, the lifeline, and the world's standards, with the greatest care for the vulnerable. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Mali's particular situation. The mercury framework supplies a concrete, global standard for reducing the poison of the gold without ending the gold itself. The delta's defence supplies the transboundary standing over the river that sustains the nation. The livelihoods supply the unifying, non-ideological stake that draws support across every divide. And the international frameworks and partners supply the standards, the leverage, and the support that reach a poor, aid-dependent state. Each covers the others' limits: the mercury framework where the poison must be reduced, the delta's defence where the river is at stake, the livelihoods where a unifying cause is needed, and the international frameworks where a poor state must be reached from beyond. An effort that grasps this division of labour, and pursues each front together and carefully, makes the fullest use of the several levers that a poor, gold-rich, delta-fed, troubled nation uniquely provides, while keeping the safety of the vulnerable at the centre throughout.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of poison and loss becomes different arguments for the state, the miners, the river authority, the partners, and the public. Translate deliberately, and always toward reducing the poison and defending the lifeline.

For the State and Its Agencies

The state responds to **health, the frameworks it has joined, and the livelihoods of its people**. Frame the harm as a threat to the water, food, and health of millions and a matter of the frameworks Mali has committed to: here is the poison, the drying delta, the frameworks, the millions who depend. Give them the health case and the frameworks, and press for reduced poison and a defended delta. Make it concrete: *here is the harm to our water and food, here is the framework, here is what protects our people*. This is the argument a poor, aid-dependent state must weigh.

For the Mining Sector

The mining sector responds to **the law, the standards, its reputation, and its licence**. Frame the harm as a breach of standards and a risk to reputation and licence: here is the poison, the health harm, the cleaner practice and benefit expected. Give them the evidence and the standards, and press for mercury-free and cleaner practice, remediation, and benefit-sharing. A company mindful of its standards and licence, or an artisanal sector offered safer ways and support, can reduce the poison.

For the River Authority and Partners

The river authority and partners respond to **the shared river, the frameworks, and the delta's protection**. Frame the harm as a matter of the shared river and the delta that feeds millions: here is the threat from upstream, the diversion, the drought, the framework's requirements. Give them the assessments and the stakes, and press for the delta's flow and proper assessment of upstream projects. A basin authority and partners charged with the shared river can defend the delta.

For the Public and the Affected

The public and the affected respond to **their own water, fish, herds, and health**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: here is the water we drink and fish, poisoned; here is the delta that feeds us, drying. Frame it as the defence of the water, food, and health of the people. Keep it accurate and careful; and protect the vulnerable, for in a troubled land the affected must not be endangered. And speak to the shared lifeline of a nation.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, never demand the impossible end of gold, and protect the vulnerable above all. Your credibility rests on the real poison, the real loss, and the real harm to health and livelihoods — reducing and defending, not ending or confronting; and safety is paramount in a troubled land. State the harm precisely, tie it to health, the lifeline, and the frameworks, and press carefully through the community and the partners. An effort that is precise, realistic, and grounded in health and livelihoods is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches, and far safer than one that courts confrontation in an insecure land.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, in a troubled, military-ruled land, the domestic space is constrained and can be dangerous, so the "media" that works is careful documentation and the international channels that reach a poor, aid-dependent state and the world's frameworks. The story — the water and food of millions, poisoned and drying — resonates, if told carefully and safely.

Why Media Matters

The state, the miners, the river authority, the partners, and the public behave differently when the poison and the loss are visible. Media does three things here: **it connects the affected communities to the technical and partner world**, **it raises the stakes** for a state mindful of its frameworks and its aid, and **it reaches the international partners and the world's conscience**. But Mali is troubled and insecure, with a constrained press, so the media effort runs largely through **international development and environmental media, the frameworks' channels, and careful factual documentation**, protecting the vulnerable, rather than confrontational domestic press.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the water, the food, and the health. The strongest frame is concrete and human: *the water that millions drink and fish is being poisoned by the gold, and the great delta that feeds the nation is drying — and the health and food of millions are at stake*. Put the water, food, and health first, because the lifeline of millions reaches everyone and unites them. Keep it scrupulously accurate and careful; and never endanger the affected. The Malian story is powerful because the water and food of millions are genuinely at stake, and the world's frameworks are meant to protect them. This is the heart of the matter, and it is worth stating plainly why it gives a Malian effort its distinctive force. The power of the case lies not in the nation's wealth or stability, which are lacking, but in the sheer, basic, human stake of the water and food of millions: it is the river that gives the nation its drink and its fish, the delta that feeds well over a million people, the gold that poisons the very water those people depend on. An effort that framed itself as opposition to the gold or the authorities would be both dangerous and easily dismissed. An effort that holds up the water people drink, the fish and herds they live on, and the health of their children asks only that the most basic needs of the people be protected, which is a stake no government, company, or partner can honourably deny, and which the world's mercury, wetland, and river frameworks exist precisely to safeguard. That is why the basic, human, unifying stake of the water and food of millions, joined to the world's frameworks that are meant to protect them, is the strategic core of the entire Malian approach, and the reason that even in a poor and troubled land, careful work in defence of the people's most basic needs can genuinely help.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to the danger. **International development and environmental media** for the world and the partners; **the frameworks' channels** for the mercury, wetland, and river standards; **technical and scientific publication** for the institutions; and **careful, protected documentation** for the record. Because the domestic space is constrained and insecure, the international and framework channels matter most, and the safety of the affected comes first — the poisoning of the water and food of millions is the story's careful power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, careful, and safe — the aim is reducing the poison and defending the lifeline, not exaggeration or endangering anyone. Frame the story around the water, food, and health, and be mindful of the insecurity and the sensitivities of a military-ruled, conflict-affected land. Handle the government, the security situation, the foreign and regional dimensions, and the mining sector factually and with care, protecting the vulnerable. And sustain the story through the ongoing harm. Above all, let the real, human stake — the water and food of millions — carry the story, because that is where a Malian effort is strongest, and let safety govern always.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real harm, the real poison or loss, and the real lifeline, keep it factual and careful, protect the vulnerable, and aim to reduce and defend. Here the health case, and the frameworks, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — [mine / dam / diversion] and its impact on our water

To [ministry / agency / authority],

I am writing on behalf of [community / group] regarding [the mine / dam / diversion] and its effects on [our river / the delta / our water]. To understand and respond, we respectfully request the **environmental and water-impact assessments**, the **pollution and monitoring data**, and the **relevant permits and studies** for the affected area. We wish to protect the water and food our communities depend on.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8B: The Mercury / Health Case

Subject: Reducing the poison in our water at [location]

To [environment / health / mines authority],

The gold mining at [location] releases mercury and cyanide that poison our water, fish, and soil and harm our health. In keeping with the global mercury framework Mali has joined, we respectfully urge safer, cleaner practices, support for mercury-free methods, and the protection of our water and health. We attach the evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8C: Defending the Delta

Subject: Protecting the Inner Niger Delta that feeds our people

To [water ministry / river basin authority],

The [upstream dam / diversion / drought] threatens the flood and flow of the Inner Niger Delta, which sustains the fishing, farming, and herding of well over a million people. Under the shared governance of the Niger, we respectfully urge proper assessment of the upstream project, the defence of the delta's flow, and sustainable water management. We attach the impact evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8D: The Livelihoods Case

Subject: The livelihoods of our fishers, farmers, and herders at [location]

To [authority / partner],

The [harm] at [location] threatens the fishing, farming, and herding on which our communities live and the nation feeds. We respectfully urge that their water, land, and livelihoods be protected, for they are the food and living of millions. We attach our account and the evidence.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8E: To an International Framework or Partner

Subject: Support for our water, delta, and health under [the framework]

Dear [framework body / donor / NGO],

We write regarding [the poison / the delta's threat] affecting the water, food, and health of our communities, in relation to [the mercury / wetland / river framework]. We respectfully seek your support in reducing the poison, defending the delta, and protecting our livelihoods, in keeping with the frameworks and standards you uphold. We provide the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8F: To the Mining Sector

Subject: Cleaner practice and benefit at [location]

To [company / cooperative],

The mining at [location] harms our water and health. We respectfully urge cleaner, mercury-reduced practice, remediation of the harm, and a fair share of the benefit for the affected communities, in keeping with the standards and your licence. We attach the evidence and welcome dialogue.

Respectfully,

[Name, group, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: The water and food of millions, poisoned and drying

Dear [journalist / editor],

In Mali, the gold boom is poisoning the water that millions drink and fish, and the great delta that feeds the nation is drying. There is a powerful, human story here about the water, food, and health of millions, and we can provide the science, the community's voices, and an account told with care for the safety of those involved.

Sincerely,

[Name, group, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our water, our fish, our herds, our health — let us defend them

Dear neighbours,

The water we drink and fish is being poisoned by the gold, and the delta that feeds us is drying. Together — fishers, farmers, herders, and all who share the water — by documenting the harm, making the health and livelihoods case, defending the delta, and using the world's frameworks, we can reduce the poison and defend the water and food of our people, carefully and safely. Please join us, with care: share what you know, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, group]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a harm is acute — a mine poisoning a river, a dam or diversion drying the delta, a spill, a contamination — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and most safely here, which means the health case, the livelihoods, and the international frameworks, protecting the vulnerable.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what is harmed, and whose water, food, and health it threatens**. Identify the immediate harm — a **poisoning, a drying, a spill, a contamination** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **affected community, the technical experts, and the international partners** at once, because in Mali the health case, the livelihoods, and the frameworks are the fastest routes to real leverage — and protect the vulnerable from the start, for the conditions are insecure.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The health and water case** can be raised at once, reaching everyone who drinks and fishes. **The livelihoods argument** can be made immediately, uniting the affected. **The international frameworks and partners** can be engaged quickly. **The community's own knowledge** can be gathered fast. These outpace the slower work of the river governance and the sector reform — which must follow — because the health, the livelihoods, and the partners can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, if a poison is spreading in the water, raise the health case fast, because the water and health of the people is a stake none can ignore.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the community and partners fast, with care. Reach immediately to the **affected community, the technical experts, and the international partners**, protecting the vulnerable. A coalition making the health and livelihoods case and engaging the frameworks is the most a rapid Malian effort can do, safely. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the health case, and the frameworks before the crisis breaks, and work carefully, protecting all involved.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the field is tilted by the nation's dependence on gold, by the complex threats to the delta from upstream and from Mali's own needs, by military rule and a grinding conflict that make much of the land insecure, by poverty, and by the powerful interests tied to the gold and the security. Name it plainly, because pretending gold is not a mainstay, or that the delta's threats are simple, or that the conditions are safe, would be false — but the health of the people, the lifeline of the delta, and the world's frameworks make even this tilted field one where careful work can help.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **Gold is a mainstay** — the economy and millions of livelihoods depend on it. **The delta's threats are complex** — partly upstream, partly Mali's own need. **The land is troubled and insecure** — military rule and conflict constrain and endanger. **And poverty and powerful interests weigh** — the state is poor and the gold and security interests strong. But **the health of the people, the lifeline, and the frameworks** are real and unifying. This is a tilt of gold-dependence, complex threats, insecurity, and poverty, worked through health, the lifeline, livelihoods, and the frameworks, carefully, not

through ending gold or open confrontation.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers of health, the lifeline, and the frameworks. Lean on the **mercury and health case**, which reaches everyone; the **delta's defence** through the river framework; the **livelihoods**, which unite; the **international frameworks and partners**, which reach a poor state; and the **community**, carefully mobilised. Meet the gold not with a demand to end it but with the case for reducing its poison and sharing its benefit. And build the technical record and the international relationships over time, because in a poor, aid-dependent state these accumulate into influence. A field tilted by gold, insecurity, and poverty is worked through health, the lifeline, and the frameworks, with the greatest care for the vulnerable, not through confrontation the conditions make dangerous.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little visible change — the poison may spread, the delta may dry, the mining may go on — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; gold is a mainstay and the conditions hard. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **poison was documented, the health case was made, the delta's defence was pressed, the livelihoods were named, and the frameworks were engaged** — and every mercury reduction, every delta flow defended, every livelihood protected, every framework advanced makes a real difference to the water and food of millions. Press, carefully, for reduced poison and a defended lifeline; even if progress is slow, the harm you documented and the health case you made will shape the next decision, because the water and food of millions is a stake that cannot forever be ignored.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In Mali, alongside the honest burdens of gold-dependence and conflict, there can be a concern of poor governance in the gold and resource sectors: mining deals struck opaquely, gold smuggled and its revenue captured, and the wealth of the land not serving its people or their environment. This must be approached with great care in an insecure, military-ruled land, and the safer, more effective route runs through the international frameworks, the transparency standards, and the health and livelihoods case.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

In many resource-rich, troubled states there is a line between the ordinary tilt of a gold economy and the capture of its wealth by the few. The marks are specific: **mining deals struck without transparency, gold and revenue diverted or smuggled, oversight evaded, and the wealth of the land not serving its people or their water**. Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish the ordinary hardship of a poor economy from provable, documented capture**, and rely on the international transparency frameworks, the mercury and basin standards, and the health and livelihoods case, because in an insecure land these are safer and more credible than accusation. And note that the capture of the gold's wealth deprives the very people whose water it poisons.

Responding to Capture — Through the Frameworks, Carefully

Where capture is real, the response runs through the international frameworks and the careful, protected channels. Use the **international transparency frameworks** for the mining and resource sector to press for openness. Use the **mercury, wetland, and river frameworks** to hold the harm to global standards. Use the **health and livelihoods case** to show that the captured wealth poisons the people's water and food. And use the **international partners and donors** who support transparency and the environment. Document

carefully and protect everyone involved, for in an insecure land the record must be rigorous and the people shielded. Route the effort through the frameworks, the transparency standards, and the health case — never through open confrontation, which the conditions make dangerous.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note matters most of all here. Mali is under military rule and gripped by a grinding conflict, with insecurity across much of its land, armed groups, and real dangers to those who speak out, so this work must be done with the greatest care. Favour the **community, technical, and international channels** over open confrontation; protect individuals absolutely, especially the vulnerable fishing, farming, herding, and mining communities and any local advocates who could be endangered; frame the work around health, water, and livelihoods, not around challenging authority; avoid the conflict zones and the armed actors entirely; and handle the government, the security situation, the foreign and regional dimensions, and the sensitive matters factually and with the utmost discretion. Care here is not caution but necessity: the effective and safe path in Mali runs through the health of the people, the lifeline of the delta, and the world's frameworks, and any straying into confrontation or into danger could cost vulnerable people gravely while achieving less than careful work through the frameworks and the community.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all through health, the lifeline, and the frameworks, with care. Here is how they fit into a single, careful Malian effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the poison-and-loss file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the community-and-framework coalition, organises the affected people, the experts, and the partners, carefully. **Legal, regulatory, and resource-governance** work presses the mercury framework, the delta's defence, and the livelihoods. **Media**, largely international, carries the water-and-livelihoods cause. The poison-and-loss feeds all five at once — a documented harm is a health case, a delta defence, a livelihoods argument, and a framework claim together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, joining community, experts, and frameworks, they compound into the defence of the water and food of millions.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the poison and the loss; identify the health case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, and the frameworks; build the community-and-framework coalition and begin documentation, protecting the vulnerable. **Middle (months 2–18):** press the mercury framework and the health case; defend the delta through the river framework; make the livelihoods argument; and engage the international partners. **Later (months and years):** see the poison reduced, the delta's flow defended, the livelihoods protected, and the frameworks advanced. A Malian effort works through health, the lifeline, and the frameworks, and its fruits — reduced poison, defended flow, protected livelihoods — are gradual; pace it accordingly, and let the protection of the vulnerable govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the poison and the loss; make the health and livelihoods case; defend the delta through the river framework; use the global**

frameworks; work carefully through the community; and protect the vulnerable. The coalition that presses all five, joining community, experts, and frameworks, and protecting the vulnerable, is the one that can genuinely reduce the poison and defend the water and food of millions — the kind of result a poor, troubled, gold-dependent nation allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive harm in Mali is genuinely difficult, and bound up with the nation's dependence on gold, with the complex threats to the delta from upstream and from Mali's own needs, with military rule and a grinding conflict that make much of the land insecure, and with deep poverty, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: gold is a mainstay, the delta's threats complex, the nation troubled and insecure, and no victory final. And yet the effort is far from futile, because the poison of the gold can be reduced through global frameworks and safer ways, because the delta that feeds millions can be defended through the river's shared governance, because the livelihoods of fishers, farmers, and herders are a powerful and unifying stake, because international frameworks and partners reach a poor and aid-dependent state, and because community and expertise are channels even a troubled nation permits — and those levers of the mercury case, the delta's defence, the livelihoods, the frameworks, and the community channels are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The poison of the gold can be reduced — through the global mercury framework and safer ways, without ending the gold millions depend on. The delta that feeds millions can be defended through the shared river. The livelihoods of fishers, farmers, and herders unite and compel. But gold is a mainstay, the threats complex, and the conditions insecure.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive levers of health, the lifeline, and the frameworks, and the honest weight of a poor, troubled, gold-dependent land.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the care — that give these efforts their force. Document the poison and the loss. Make the health and livelihoods case. Defend the delta through the river framework. Use the global frameworks. Work carefully through the community. And protect the vulnerable — because in a poor, troubled nation whose water and food are at stake, an effort that reduces the poison and defends the lifeline through health, livelihoods, and the world's frameworks, carried carefully and protecting those who act, is the one that is both effective and just.

Mali is a great and ancient land of the Niger, whose life flows from the river and the vast inland delta at its heart, feeding well over a million people with its fish and floating rice and dry-season pastures, and whose earth is rich with the gold that made its old empires famous — and its environmental struggle is that the same gold now poisons the water with mercury while the delta that feeds the nation is squeezed by dams and drought, in a land under military rule and gripped by a hard conflict. This guide has hidden none of that, nor pretended that gold can be wished away, or that the delta's fate is simple, or that the conditions are safe, and there is no landmark victory to promise you. But the water and food of millions are a stake that even a troubled nation cannot finally ignore, and the levers are real: the global frameworks that can reduce the poison of the gold, the shared governance that can defend the delta, the livelihoods that unite the people, and the world's partners who stand with a poor land. There is no ending the gold that feeds millions, and no easy command of a river that rises beyond the border; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted above all on the safety of those who act. But the water and delta and people of Mali are worth every careful effort, the levers that run through health, the lifeline, and the world's frameworks are real, and the patient, careful, protected work of documenting the poison, making the health case, and defending the delta is one that Malians and their allies can genuinely do — and, carefully and safely, defend the water and food of millions.

So can you.